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Mrs. Rangel

ERWC - 1st

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Dear Coalinga High School Board of Directors, I am reaching out to you to urge Coalinga High School to start classes at 8:30 a.m., just like most high schools in California. This change shouldn't be purely for convenience; it's an imperative step into supporting students' mental, physical, and emotional well-being and their academic success. Both research and personal experiences from members of our community, including my two adults and one student, highlight the many benefits of starting school later. When teenagers are going through puberty, their biological clocks shift. Wendy Troxel explained that melatonin doesn't release until around 11 p.m., which is much later in younger children or adults. Which means waking up teens at 6:00 a.m. is like waking adults at 4:00 a.m., leading to chronic sleep deprivation that harms learning and their emotional health. Troxel notes that she is "literally robbing her son of his dreams," which she refers to as not getting deep sleep, which is important for memory and emotional processing (Troxel). Later start times can improve a kid's life in many ways, according to an increasing amount of scientific data and the perspectives of local educators, parents, and medical professionals. Ana Maria shared her firsthand experience: "My daughter wakes up around the same time I head to work, and I wake up at 3:40 a.m. because I have to leave by 5:00 a.m. I have to wake her up at 4:00 a.m. so she can shower and get ready.

I see how she struggles to get up in the morning, and if the school times were changed to start at 8:30 a.m., it would help not only her but also other students out so much. They would get to wake up later and get the sleep they need.” (Ana Maria). I highly encourage that these strong arguments be taken into consideration and that these changes be put into effect. A teen's natural delay in their sleep cycles is one of the major changes that happen in their body. Their characteristic teenage years are a unique developmental stage in their lives. Teenagers are naturally supposed to wake up later in the morning because they are programmed to fall asleep later at night. So it is almost impossible for students to get the eight to ten hours per night that is recommended for teenagers, so this can't happen when school starts too early. The American Academy of Pediatrics supports this view; they recommend that middle and high schools start no earlier than 8:30 a.m. to better align with teenagers' sleep needs. Sleep deprivation is a significant effect that affects every little aspect of a student's academic performance. One of my friends explained that “yes, I do think later start times would improve academic performance. We would be more active. It's also proven that teens that don't sleep much don't do well in school. That's why it's recommended that teenagers get 8 to 10 hours of sleep because it helps them in school but mainly helps them function better” (Jennifer Lopez).

Brain functions like remembering, concentrating, and problem-solving are all critical for learning, so they are required. Studies show that students that have school start at 8:30 tend to get higher grades and have better test scores. There are some concerns about school starting later, which could challenge transportation and after-school programs. A classmate says, “My family wouldn't face any challenges if the school started later, but I can't speak for others.” Families could face difficulties with their kids coming home later or if they're involved in sports.”

(Jennifer Lopez). While these concerns are proper, there are many districts that have successfully adjusted their bus routines and their programs without harming their students' participation and family routines. In conclusion, changing Coalinga High School's start time to 8:30 a.m. is a resource-supported decision that would have an amazing improvement in students' sleep, academic achievement, mental health, and safety. So I strongly suggest that the board dedicate this change to creating a better and more productive learning environment for all the students. Thank you for your time and consideration. I am confident that with thoughtful planning and community collaboration, Coalinga High School can successfully implement this change and set a positive example for student-centered education.